

4,000 YEARS OF HOSPITALITY

HOSPITALITY: A JOURNEY THROUGH TIME

BABYLON TO BOSTON — HOW THE WORLD BUILT THE SPACE

~1974 BCE
BABYLON

BABYLONIAN TAVERN LAW

The Code of Hammurabi imposed severe penalties — including death — for tavern keepers who diluted beer or overcharged customers. Hospitality was state-regulated commerce. These were the earliest recorded hospitality standards in human history.

Source: *Star Tavern*, startavern.net

800-1974 BCE
ANCIENT GREECE

XENIA, LESCHES & PHATNAI

Greek culture institutionalized hospitality as sacred law. The *lesche* — a place for council and conversation — and the *phatnai* served travelers, traders, and diplomats. Refusing a stranger shelter was a religious offense against Xenios, protector of guests and strangers.

Source: *HRC International*, hrc-international.com; *Star Tavern*, startavern.net

200 BCE-400 CE
ANCIENT ROME

ROMAN MANSIONES & TABERNAE

Rome established *mansiones* — state-run inns for officials along road networks. Private *tabernae* served the common traveler. Though considered socially disreputable, Roman taverns attracted every class of society, including senators who attended in disguise.

Source: *HRC International*, hrc-international.com; *Star Tavern*, startavern.net

500-1500 CE
MEDIEVAL EUROPE

MONASTERIES, GUILDS & PILGRIM ROUTES

Religious institutions became the primary hospitality infrastructure of medieval Europe, housing pilgrims traveling to Canterbury, Rome, and Santiago de Compostela. Guilds then took over regulation of tavern standards, introducing formalized quality controls. English inns sheltered travelers, criminals, and political rebels alike.

Source: *HRC International*, hrc-international.com; *Star Tavern*, startavern.net

1607-1700S
COLONIAL AMERICA

THE AMERICAN ORDINARY — HOSPITALITY AS INFRASTRUCTURE

Samuel Cole opened Boston's first licensed tavern on March 4, 1634. Towns were legally required to have a tavern — towns without one faced fines. Taverns were one per 100-130 residents, spaced 8 miles apart on stagecoach routes, serving as bank, court, post office, auction house, and meeting hall simultaneously.

Source: *Star Tavern*, startavern.net; *Colonial Williamsburg Foundation*; *Gettysburg Historical Journal*